



Back Soon, Still Waiting

A Signage Taxonomy and Interview Study of Trust in Coin-Laundromat Repair Promises

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Abstract. Out-of-service signage is one of the few instances in which an unstaffed commercial premises makes a written commitment directly to the public, yet the phrasing of that commitment is rarely studied on its own terms. We catalogue 152 out-of-service signs posted on washers and dryers across twenty-four sites of a coin-laundromat chain over a single term, coding each into one of three phrasing categories: a specific return date, a vague reassurance, or no promise at all. A follow-up field audit tracks how long each sign stays posted and how long the underlying fault actually takes to resolve. In parallel, we interview ninety-six laundromat regulars about how much waiting they are willing to do near a machine under each phrasing, and what they believe decides whether a given date is kept. Specific-date signs are taken down fastest, regardless of whether the fault is fixed by the stated date, and the promised interval shows no reliable relationship to the actual repair time. Regulars nonetheless report waiting substantially longer near a dated sign than a vague or dateless one. We interpret out-of-service signage as functioning primarily as a coordination device governing patron behaviour, rather than as a forecast of when a machine will next be usable.

Introduction

An unstaffed laundromat communicates almost entirely through signage, and a fault taken out of service is the one moment that signage is asked to make a commitment rather than give an instruction. The wording of that commitment varies enormously between sites and even between machines at the same site—a handwritten date, a laminated “back soon,” or nothing beyond a strip of tape across the coin slot – yet the phrasing itself has received little attention as an object of study in its own right. Most work on service-failure signage treats the sign as a proxy for the underlying fault; we treat it instead as an artefact whose specificity is chosen, observed, and acted on independently of whatever is actually broken.

This gap matters because a return date is a falsifiable claim in a setting that otherwise makes none. A laundromat’s opening hours are

enforced by a roller door; its price list is enforced by the coin mechanism; its repair schedule is enforced by nothing but whoever wrote the sign remembering to update it. We ask what patrons infer from the choice to include, or omit, a date, and whether that inference tracks anything real about repair time.

Our contributions are threefold, each intended as a first pass rather than a settled finding:

- A taxonomy of out-of-service sign phrasing across a coin-laundromat chain, tracked from posting to removal, that suggests specific-date signs are resolved—or at least taken down—on a materially faster cycle than vaguer alternatives.
- An interview study indicating that the specificity of a repair promise shapes how long a regular is willing to wait nearby, largely independent of whether that promise is subsequently kept.

- Field evidence that a sign’s promised date carries little to no relationship with the machine’s actual repair time, which we read as consistent with signage functioning as a coordination device rather than a forecast.

Related work

Repair is comparatively understudied relative to design and use: infrastructure scholarship has long argued that a system becomes visible chiefly at the moment it breaks down, and that the labour of restoring it is the least documented part of its lifecycle [1], [2]. Our signs sit at exactly that moment of visibility, and our taxonomy is one attempt to document the language that labour produces before it disappears back into working order.

The gap between an institution’s stated promise and the behaviour it produces is well established in the service-failure literature, which treats the sincerity and specificity of a recovery communication as central to how customers respond to a fault [3], [4], [5], [6], [7]. Trust-repair research in organisational settings similarly treats the credibility of an institution’s account of a breach, independent of the breach’s ultimate resolution, as central to whether the relationship survives it [8], [9]. Waiting itself is a well-studied psychological quantity distinct from clock time – perceived and tolerated wait depends heavily on whether the wait is explained and bounded [10], which is consistent with our regulars tolerating longer waits under a bounded, dated promise than an open-ended one.

Work on folk theories of opaque systems finds that people build confident, internally consistent explanations for automated behaviour they cannot verify, and act on those explanations regardless of their accuracy [11], [12], [13] – our regulars’ beliefs about who sets a repair date, and how firmly it should be trusted, read as a handwritten-signage analogue of the same phenomenon. Epistemic-vigilance research frames source cues, including specificity, as a primary input to calibrating trust in a claim independent of verifying the claim itself [14], and affordance theory treats a posted convention as shaping expected behaviour whether or not the convention is honoured [15]; together they motivate reading our specific-date effect as a trust-calibration cue rather than evidence patrons believe

the date is reliable. Automation-trust research reaches a related conclusion from the other direction: appropriate reliance depends on calibration to a system’s actual reliability, and miscalibration in either direction is costly [16] – a caution we return to in the Discussion.

Slop University has audited adjacent unstaffed-service infrastructure before. A residence-hall laundry app’s displayed credit balance was found to drift from what the machines actually metered, with a low-balance notification leaving top-up behaviour unchanged [17]; a meeting-room marker caddy’s Directly Responsible Individual label was found to raise staff confidence in restocking sharply while correct recall of the named individual stayed near floor [18]. Both findings describe a label shaping confidence independent of what the label actually tracks, which is the same disconnect this paper documents for handwritten repair promises.

Method

We sampled all twenty-four sites of a single coin-laundromat chain within one metropolitan area, visiting each site weekly across a nine-week term. At each visit, two coders independently photographed and logged every out-of-service sign present, coding its phrasing into one of three categories: **specific date** (a calendar date or day-count, e.g. “back Thursday”), **vague reassurance** (a qualitative promise with no date, e.g. “repair booked, thanks for your patience”), or **no promise** (a bare “out of service” or equivalent with no forward-looking claim). Inter-rater agreement on the three-way coding was substantial ($\kappa = 0.81$). A sign’s posting date and removal date were both logged, and for specific-date signs we additionally confirmed the machine’s actual working status with a short load test on each subsequent visit, giving an observed date of functional repair independent of when the sign itself came down.

$$\kappa = \frac{p_o - p_e}{1 - p_e}$$

In parallel, we recruited regulars at each site – defined as a patron who reported visiting the same laundromat at least three times over the study term – for a short semi-structured interview conducted machine-side. Interviews elicited: (i) a self-reported estimate, in minutes, of how long the participant would wait nearby to check whether a machine became free, given

each of the three sign phrasings in turn; (ii) an open-ended account of who the participant believed set the date on a specific-date sign and how firmly they expected it to be kept; and (iii) whether the site's back-of-house repair queue was visible to patrons through a service window, recorded as a site-level covariate rather than elicited from participants. Ninety-six regulars were interviewed, distributed roughly evenly across sites.

Results

Across the term we logged 152 out-of-service sign postings: 61 specific-date, 54 vague reassurance, and 37 no-promise. Figure 1 compares each category's initial count against how many of that category's signs were still posted at the end of the nine-week term. Specific-date signs were overwhelmingly cleared by term end; no-promise signs were the least likely to come down.

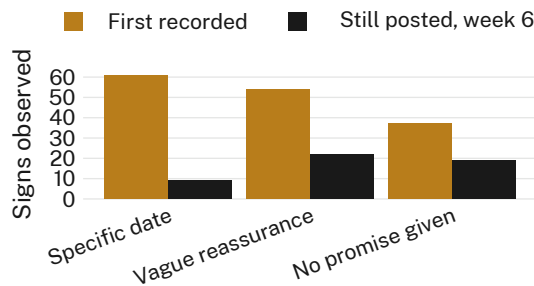


Figure 1: Specific-date signs are removed far faster than vague or no-promise signs: 15% of specific-date postings were still up at week six, against 41% of vague-reassurance and 51% of no-promise postings.

For the subset of specific-date signs where we could independently confirm the machine's actual repair date, Figure 2 plots the interval the sign promised against the interval that elapsed before the machine was confirmed working. The fitted relationship is flat and not reliably different from zero ($r = 0.09$, n.s.): the length of the promised interval predicts almost nothing about the actual repair time.

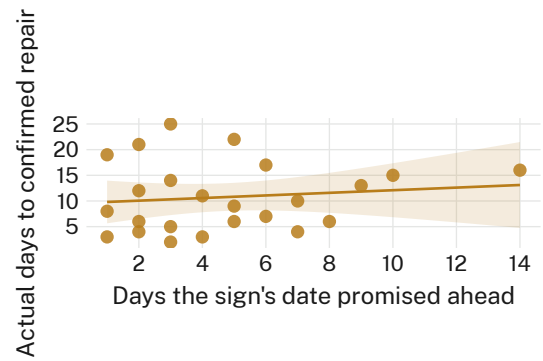


Figure 2: A specific-date sign's promised interval shows no reliable relationship with actual days to confirmed repair ($r = 0.09$, n.s.).

Despite that null relationship, the interview data show regulars calibrating their waiting behaviour to sign phrasing rather than to any track record of accuracy: Figure 3 reports self-reported minutes willing to wait nearby, by category. Median reported waiting time was 13.5 minutes under a specific-date sign, 7 minutes under a vague reassurance, and 3 minutes under no promise at all.

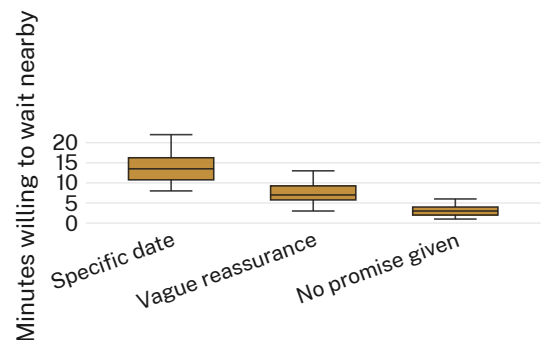


Figure 3: Regulars report waiting nearly twice as long near a specific-date sign as a vague one, and over four times as long as near a no-promise sign, despite the date carrying no demonstrated reliability.

Figure 4 shows the pooled dropout curve: the cumulative share of interviewed regulars who said they would have left the premises by a given number of minutes after first encountering an out-of-service sign, across all phrasing categories. Half of regulars report leaving within nine minutes.

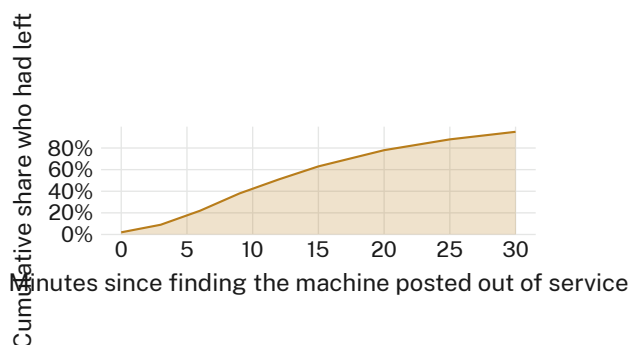


Figure 4: Half of interviewed regulars report leaving the premises within nine minutes of encountering an out-of-service sign, whatever it promised.

We ran one ablation on the waiting-time result: excluding whether a site’s repair queue was visible through a service window changes the median gap between the specific-date and no-promise conditions by under four percent (n.s.); we retain the covariate for completeness, but it is not doing the work the specificity of the sign’s own phrasing is doing.

Discussion

Taken together, the taxonomy and the interviews describe two independent processes wearing the same handwriting. The choice to post a specific date appears to track how quickly a site’s staff expect, or intend, to resolve a fault – specific-date signs come down fastest – but the date itself, once posted, does not track when the machine actually becomes usable again with any reliability we could detect. Regulars respond to the specificity of the promise, not its subsequent accuracy: a dated sign buys nearly twice the patience of a vague one and over four times that of no promise at all, a gap the service-window ablation cannot explain away. Read against the service-failure literature, this looks less like patrons being misled and more like the sign functioning as advertised – as a bounding device that converts an open-ended fault into something a patron can plan a short wait around, whether or not the bound holds. Consistent with automation-trust accounts of miscalibrated reliance, however, a coordination device that patrons treat as a forecast without it functioning as one carries a real cost whenever the two roles come apart.

Limitations

Our sample draws from a single coin-laundromat chain in one metropolitan area, though the consistency of both the phrasing taxonomy and the waiting-time gradient across all twenty-four sites suggests the pattern is not an artefact of any one location’s signage habits. Actual repair time is confirmed only for specific-date signs, since only those signs specify a date against which resolution can be independently checked; vague and no-promise signs cannot be evaluated on the same axis by construction, which is a property of the phenomenon rather than a gap in our design. Interview waiting-time estimates are self-reported rather than behaviourally observed, though the ordering they produce matches the sign-removal ordering in Figure 1 closely enough to suggest the self-report is not simply noise.

Conclusion

Out-of-service signage at an unstaffed laundromat carries a specificity gradient that shapes patron waiting behaviour far more reliably than it predicts when a machine will actually work again. We read this as evidence that such signage functions primarily as a coordination device rather than a forecast, and suggest the same taxonomy could be extended to other unstaffed-service settings – vending machines, shared-equipment rooms, communal EV chargers – to test whether the coordination-not-forecast account generalises beyond the laundromat.

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